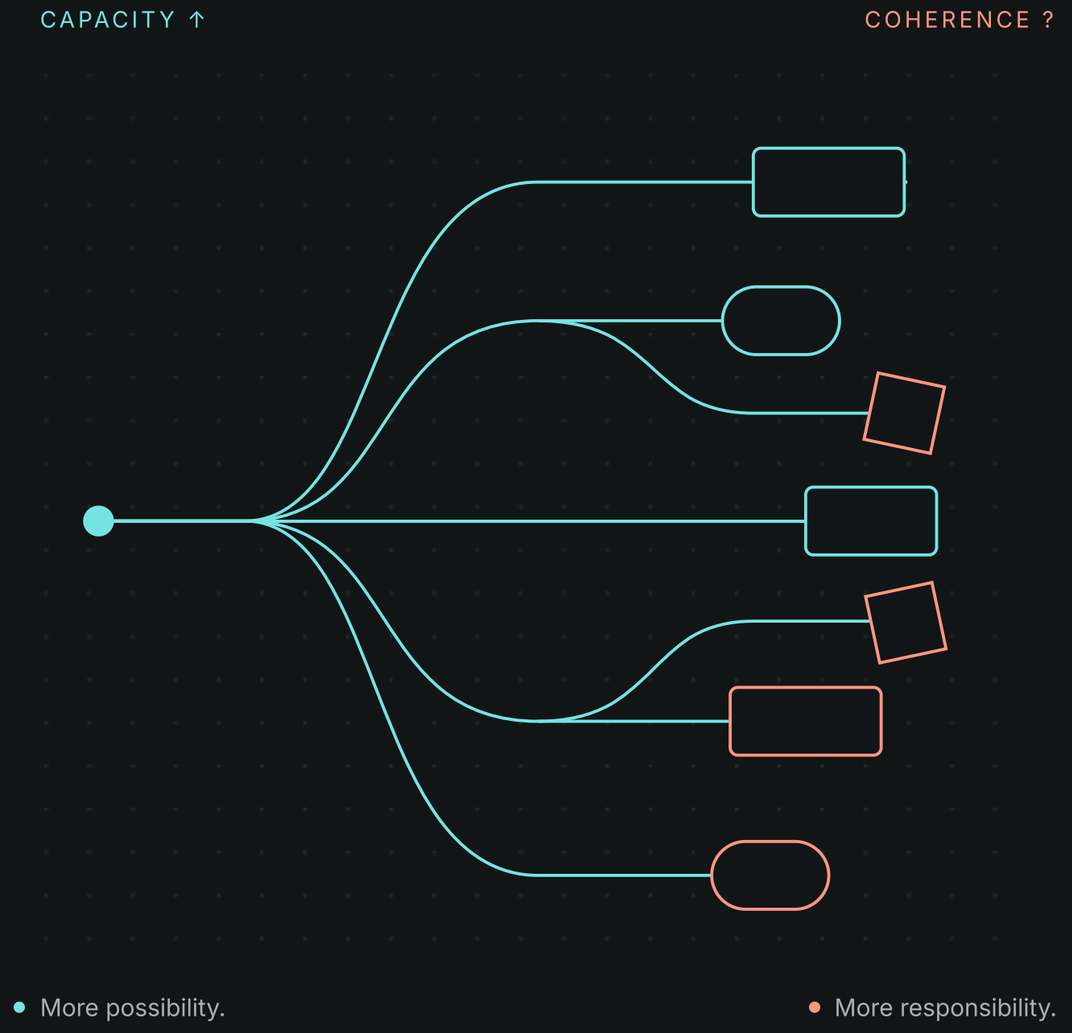
# AI makes us faster. Who keeps us coherent?

Governance, systems, and the new role of DesignOps in product teams



# The AI production floor is everywhere.



## Product

- Brief
- Requirements
- Hypotheses



## Research

- Synthesis
- Insights
- Questions



## Design

- Concepts
- Prototypes
- Patterns



## Engineering

- Components
- Code
- Tests

The bottleneck moves: **production → alignment → quality.**



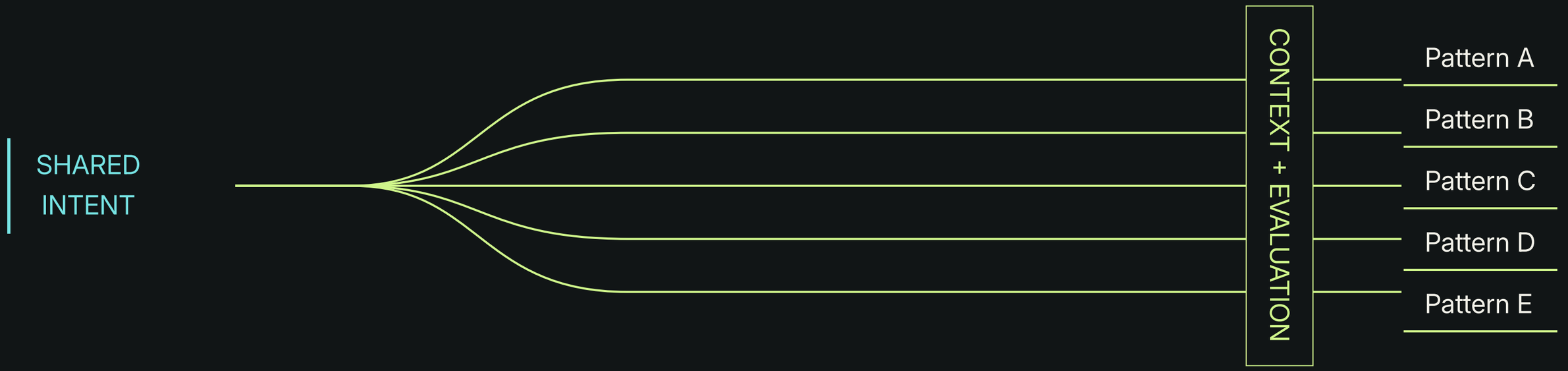
# Julian Alvarado

## Xbox Design Ops

- Design Operations at Xbox / Microsoft.
- Sr. Creative Operations Manager for Prime Video.
- 18 years of experience managing projects at companies including P&G, Publicis, Critical Mass and Automattic (WordPress).
- Daily CrossFit. Jiu-jitsu “forever blue belt.” Retired musician and lots of drawing at home.

# AI doesn't just accelerate work. It accelerates variation.

More output → More variation → More decisions → More inconsistency




Distinct ideas. Shared constraints. Accountable decisions.

# Three questions.
# One coherent system.

## GOVERN

What should we use and how should we use it?

## CONTEXT

The intelligence layer for the right choices.

## EVALUATE

What makes it good enough?

# Fix the form. Keep the lesson.



STEP 6 OF 6

## Check the next result

## Can the next person start alone?

The next proposed form

Workspace name first. Invitations optional.

The review

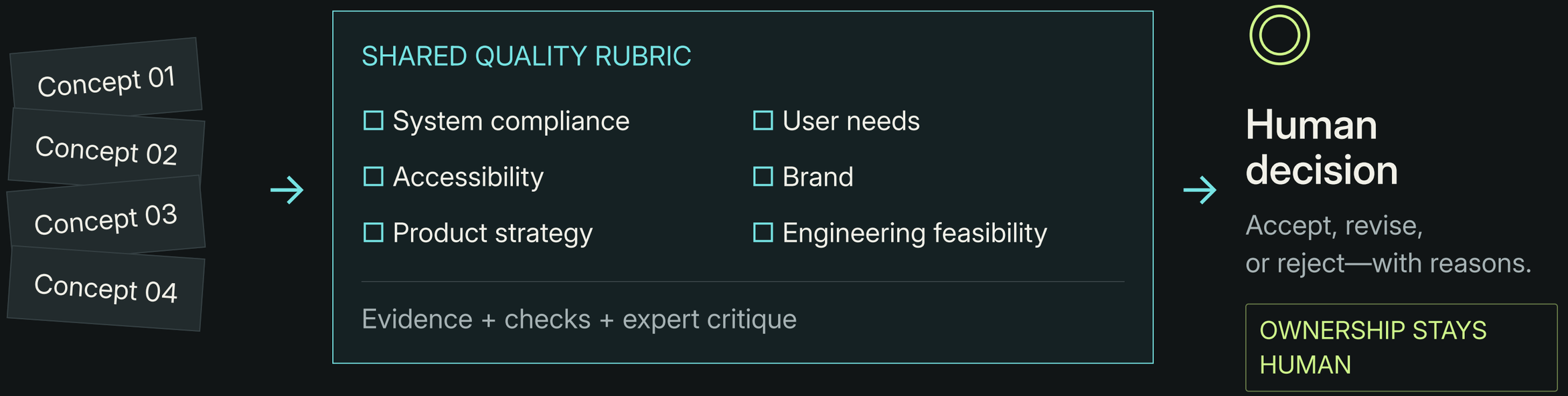
Setup works without a teammate email.

Still to check

Accessibility and whether it works for real users.

This requirement is met. The review is not over.

# Many possible outputs.
# One accountable judgment.




Automated checks inform judgment. **They do not prove a design is good.**

# Don't just save the output. Capture the learning.

Keep the decision and its reason.
Share them with the next team.

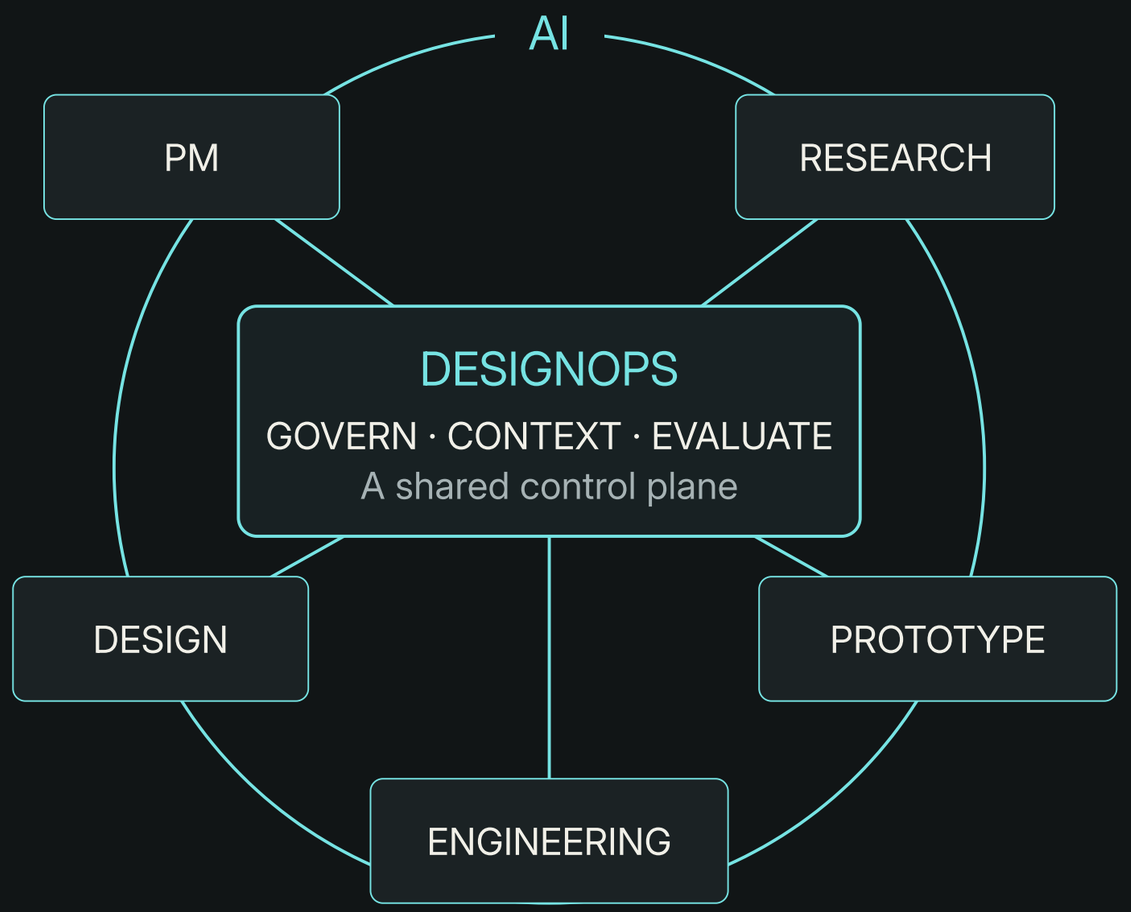
1. AI proposes a design — using shared guidance
2. The team reviews it — against the user's need
3. Save the lesson — decision + reason + owner
4. Update the guidance — for the next team + AI
5. Check the next result — do not assume success

# Same foundations.
# A larger operating system.

| FOUNDATION | TRADITIONAL FOCUS | EXPANDED AI-ERA SCOPE |
|---|---|---|
| PEOPLE | Enable designers | → Enable product teams |
| PROCESS | Optimize workflows | → Architect human–AI workflows |
| | Measure efficiency | → Measure quality + outcomes |
| | Facilitate consistency | → Govern generated variation |
| SYSTEMS | Document processes | → Encode organizational knowledge |
| | Scale design systems | → Make systems AI-readable |

# Not doing all the work. Connecting the system.

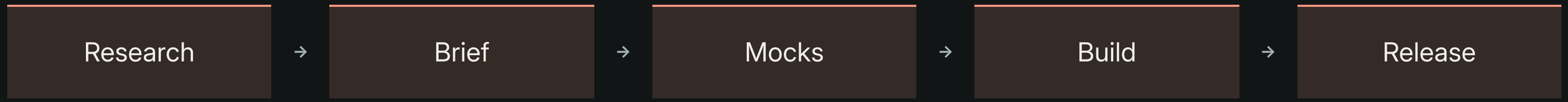
DesignOps defines the conditions under which the work happens.




Domain experts still own product decisions.

# Before accelerated production. Work moves by handoff.

## Sequential handoffs




Customer need → handoff → wait → handoff → wait → customer feedback

# Less waiting.
# More learning, together.

Shared purpose → synchronized work → AI-assisted production

Mission · Milestones · Metrics → Spec ↔ concept ↔ HTML/CSS → Experiment ↔ learn

Customer need → PM + research + design + engineering → customer feedback

Hypothesis: production can shrink; experimentation can expand. Validate it.

# Your next infrastructure is already in your documentation.

| Inputs: Documentation | | Outputs: Scalable guidelines |
|---|---|---|
| Guidelines + design system | → | Rules and scalable production |
| Templates + documentation | → | Prompts and reusable context |
| Critique + procedures | → | Evals and human + AI workflows |



Advanced context for a production sprint

Metrics Speed · Quality · Outcomes

# Faster is not the whole score.

| Metric / unit | Baseline | Pilot | Change |
|---|---|---|---|
| **WORKFLOW OUTCOME** | | | |
| **Brief → validated concept**<br>median elapsed days | 9d | 6d | −3 d |
| **Design production rate**<br>accepted artifacts / in a team with 8w E2E Cycle | ~3–4/wk | ~1–2/wk | ≈−2/wk<br>Midpoint estimate |
| **LEADING / PROCESS** | | | |
| **Review effort**<br>person-hours / accepted concept | 4h | 6h | +2 h |
| **Design-system compliance**<br>% applicable checks passed | 78% | 90% | +12 pp |

If AI becomes part of how we design products,

# who designs the system in which AI operates?

# DesignOps.

AI doesn't eliminate the need for DesignOps.
**It makes DesignOps infrastructure.**

AI creates **capacity.**

Systems create **consistency.**

Stewardship creates **trust.**

# Three ideas to take away

## Govern the system

Agree on responsibilities, rules, criteria, stacks, etc., for working with AI.

## Preserve context

Turn decisions and lessons into reusable guides and evaluations (Evals).

## Evaluate to learn

Measure quality and outcomes, not just speed or volume.

DESIGNOPS AS AI INFRASTRUCTURE

# Let's talk

LinkedIn · alvaradolj1 ↗

GitHub · JulianAlvarado ↗

# FAQ

01 Who owns governance? ↗

02 Do we become an AI team? ↗

03 What is an AI-ready design system? ↗

04 What happens when models change? ↗

05 How do we prove value? ↗

06 How does the context stack fit? ↗

07 Where does this fit in the lifecycle? ↗

08 How do we start a pilot? ↗

↖ BACK TO FAQ

# Shared governance.
# Explicit decision rights.

BOUNDARIES

## Security + Legal

Data, privacy, risk, and policy.
Set non-negotiable constraints.

ACCESS

## IT + platform teams

Approved technology and access.
Maintain secure capabilities.

OPERATING MODEL

## DesignOps

Translate policy into workflows.
Facilitate context and evaluation.

PRODUCT JUDGMENT

## Domain experts

PM, research, design, engineering.
Own quality and release decisions.

Good governance pre-approves safe paths—not every individual click.

↖ BACK TO FAQ

# Architect the environment. Don't become the AI factory.

### Governance
Rules + risk

### Design intelligence
Consumable knowledge

### Workflow architecture
With domain experts

### Quality systems
Rubrics + evidence

### Enablement
Playbooks + training

### Measurement
Quality + outcomes

ENABLE DIFFERENT KINDS OF WORK

## Prototype → Build → Improve → Grow → Maintain

Exploration, production, simplification, experimentation, and reliability need different controls.

↖ BACK TO FAQ

# A component library with the reasoning attached.

KEEP THE FOUNDATION

- Tokens
- Components
- Patterns
- Guidelines

+

MAKE IT CONSUMABLE

- Semantic metadata
- Usage rules + constraints
- Examples + code equivalents
- Evaluation criteria

| SHARED CONTEXT | Owner | Version | Source | Freshness | Access |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|

Start with one pattern: its intent, code, valid uses, forbidden uses, and checks.

↖ BACK TO FAQ

# Models change.
# Your operating principles endure.

| KNOWLEDGE | RULES | WORKFLOWS | EVALUATION |
|---|---|---|---|

Model A ↔ Model B ↔ Model C

Re-run evaluation before switching.
Model-agnostic does not mean behavior-identical.

Canonical prompts encode domain knowledge—not one person's clever phrasing.

Co-author with PMs, researchers, designers, and engineers.
Version context, permissions, examples, and acceptance criteria together.

# Measure the workflow.
# Not the number of prompts.

Operational definitions for a scoped baseline and pilot

| Metric | Definition / unit | Collection method |
|---|---|---|
| Brief → validated concept | Median elapsed days; fixed validation criteria | Brief timestamp → review + user evidence |
| Design production rate | Accepted artifacts per team-week | Same artifact class, scope, and acceptance rubric |
| Production / review effort | Person-hours per accepted concept; report separately | Time log including critique + validation |
| Rework / revision rate | % reviewed artifacts requiring a major revision | Revision log; agree “major” before starting |
| System compliance | % applicable design-system checks passed | Token, component, and interaction-pattern audit |
| Accessibility / quality defects | Open defects per 10 reviewed screens + severity | Manual and automated checks, deduplicated |
| Design-to-code divergence | % audited UI instances violating approved intent | Paired design/code review of a defined sample |
| Experimentation / reuse | Completed experiments/week; % work citing approved context | Decision log; context provenance in artifacts |

Match scope + staffing. Record sample size + spread. Audit sampling bias. Track customer task success separately.
Small pilots are directional—not causal proof. Set adoption / revise / stop criteria before seeing results.

↖ BACK TO FAQ

# The advantage isn't the model. It's the memory.

What does your organization allow the model to know?

05 **DesignOps**
Connects the system · enables adoption

04 **Stewardship**
Guardrails · exclusions · human checkpoints

03 **Organizational context**
Tokens · components · research · brand · accessibility
Terminology · workflows · repos · product experiences

02 **Agents + tools**
Design assistants · coding agents · research tools

01 **Models**
Replaceable capabilities, not institutional knowledge

↖ BACK TO FAQ

# Same infrastructure.
# Every stage of the journey.

| 01 | 02 | 03 | 04 | 05 |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| DISCOVER | DEFINE | DESIGN | BUILD | MEASURE |
| Synthesize research | Frame the problem | Explore concepts | Generate components | Interpret outcomes |

SHARED INFRASTRUCTURE — GOVERN — CONTEXT — EVALUATE

↖ Back to shared production

# One workflow.
# Thirty days. A measurable pilot.

DAYS 01–07

## Map

A map of AI use, gaps, and risk.

DAYS 08–14

## Select

One workflow with shared context.

DAYS 15–21

## Define

A review plan: owner, criteria, baseline.

DAYS 22–30

## Pilot

Comparable work, reviewed evidence.

THEN DECIDE **Adopt** / **Revise** / **Stop**